

From Hashtag to Human-Centered Insights: Rethinking Disability Awareness Across Languages

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Abstract

As global discourse on disability expands, much of the digital awareness and inclusion efforts remain anchored in English-language narratives. This linguistic dominance limits our understanding of how disability is perceived, discussed, and mobilized across culturally diverse regions— particularly within underrepresented communities in the Global South. This study investigates cross-lingual and cross-cultural perspectives on disability awareness by analyzing three years of public posts from X (formerly Twitter), using the hashtag #peoplewithdisabilities. Through natural language processing (NLP), we examine (1) posting behaviors and engagement dynamics, (2) sentiment and empathy-oriented language, and (3) culturally embedded narrative framings in both Arabic and English content. Our interdisciplinary lens draws from computational linguistics and disability studies allows us to interpret trends beyond surface metrics. Findings reveal that Arabic posts often reflect familial, religious, and collectivist viewpoints rooted in local cultural values, while English posts emphasize rights-based advocacy and individual empowerment. Emotional expression and engagement patterns also diverge, highlighting that awareness itself is not universal but culturally constructed and contextually nuanced. We argue that designing inclusive technologies requires more than linguistic translation, it demands sensitivity to the cultural frameworks shaping disability discourse.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; • **Computing methodologies** → **Lexical semantics**; • **Information systems** → **Data mining**.

Keywords

Social media, X/Twitter trends, Disability, Awareness, Empathy, Mindset, Cross-culture, Cross-language, Arabic, English, Linguistic analysis, Text mining

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1 Introduction

Disability awareness is shaped by deeply rooted cultural, spiritual and societal beliefs that influence how people with disabilities are perceived [11, 20]. Although these beliefs can range from negative stigma to collective respect, meaningful changes in mindset often require exposure to others who are different [21, 23].

In the Global North, disability rights movements have driven legal reforms to reduce inequity and promote digital inclusion [9, 19, 43]. However, accessibility gaps persist, even in regions with robust policies, due in part to the ongoing influence of the medical model of disability [35, 42, 44]. This model positions disability as a problem within the individual, requiring treatment or correction [1, 10]. In contrast, the social model emphasizes that disability arises from societal barriers and exclusion [36]. Bunbury argues that adopting the social model's language can help shift public attitudes [13]. We further suggest that the greatest barrier to progress in both the Global North and South is not infrastructure or law, but human mindset, and that sustainable change must begin there.

Social media plays a pivotal role in shaping perceptions, facilitating advocacy, and connecting communities [3, 15, 29, 31, 38]. It holds particular promise in advancing disability awareness. However, despite its global reach, most research focuses on English-language discourse, neglecting insights from the Global South. There is a pressing need for comparative, cross-lingual research to better understand how disability is discussed, framed, and interpreted online.

In this study, we investigate discourse on X (formerly Twitter) using three years of data under the hashtags #peoplewithdisabilities (#ذوي_الإعاقة) in Arabic and English. We aim to inform locally effective awareness campaigns by revealing regional differences rather than assuming a universal model of engagement.

Our contributions are centered on the following inquiries:

- We study the promotion, engagement, and patterns of change in the use of #peoplewithdisabilities (#ذوي_الإعاقة) globally across Arabic and English posts over a three-year period.
- We perform a mixed-method linguistic examination of sentiment, empathy, and narrative framing within these datasets.

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- We present insights that support inclusive, culturally responsive digital design and policy efforts across multilingual contexts.

The complete work has since been published in IEEE ACCESS [4].

1.1 Disability and Natural Language Processing (NLP) on X (i.e., Twitter)

Recent research reconfirms that societal constructs around disability are often rooted in stigma, negative sentiment, and exclusionary norms that reinforce systemic barriers [11]. This has fueled growing scholarly interest in analyzing how disabilities, ranging from mental health conditions to physical impairments, are discussed online. Studies have explored sentiment and framing around conditions such as autism [14], PTSD [45], and depression [16, 34], while others examine broader issues including diagnosis, identity, support, treatment, and assistive technologies [8, 17, 32, 46].

To study these dynamics at scale, researchers have adopted Natural Language Processing (NLP) methods to extract insights from large social media corpora. These approaches enable content analysis through tools such as text classification, sentiment detection, and psycholinguistic profiling [26]. For example, Mitchell et al. [33] applied NLP to schizophrenia-related tweets using the Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count (LIWC) tool [2], revealing user experiences and support needs.

Stigma detection is another focal point. Alvarez et al. [6] manually labeled tweets with medical experts to identify pejorative attitudes across health conditions, while others studied sentiment around specific diseases such as liver disease [30] and Alzheimer's [37]. Predictive models have also been developed to classify depressive traits from tweet content [12].

Language-based discrimination, including ableism, hate speech, and toxic content, has also been analyzed. Scholars note that such harmful language can be more subtle in certain cultural and linguistic contexts, making detection and mitigation more complex [9, 18, 22, 27].

In this work, we extend prior research by taking a broader, cross-lingual approach to understanding disability discourse on social media. Using NLP and a mixed-method lens, we examine the content and sentiment of disability-related tweets in both Arabic and English, offering insights into the cultural narratives, emotional framing, and engagement patterns that shape global awareness around disability [7, 39]. This work attempts to promote effective comparisons using established NLP methods for each language, where appropriate, both minimizing language bias and proposing a framework to support cross-linguistic research on cultural issues between and within the Global North and South.

2 Methods

2.1 Data collection

We collected data from the X platform (formerly Twitter) using the Twitter API 2.0 through an approved academic research account (acquired in March 2022), which provided access to historical data beyond the standard 7-day window. Queries were constructed using a curated list of disability-related keywords aligned with our research questions (see Table ??). To ensure the collection was

Table 1: A summary of the collected disability-related datasets. User numbers listed are the unique users.

Datasets	Ar	Query	# Users	En	Query	# Users
Hashtags						
#peoplewithdisabilities	10.1k	Q3	3041	85.5k	Q	9642
#disability #disabled (-related)	41k	Q2	9884	592k	Q2	592k

language-specific and original posts, *AR* or *EN* tags and *-is:retweet* were included in the queries.

The dataset includes posts published between **September 1, 2019 and September 30, 2022**. To ensure adequate coverage and daily representation, pagination tokens were used to retrieve up to 500 posts per day, allowing for a potential maximum of 6,480,000 posts.

For each post, we extracted the following metadata:

- Author ID and profile description
- Account verification status and location
- Post ID and full content
- Engagement metrics: repost, reply, like, and quote counts
- Network data: follower and following counts

2.2 Pre-processing and Data Analysis

We perform quantitative analysis of the multiple datasets to help build the bigger picture by answering a set of questions for each of the two target hashtags (#peoplewithdisabilities and #disability in both languages) revolving around their location, engagement, sentiment, behaviour, hate speech and offensive/toxic language, and language analysis ¹. To study location and sources, engagement and word usage common data analytics and modeling libraries in Python were used [24].

To study **sentiment** automated pre-trained models for English 1) TextBlob ² and for Arabic 2) Mazajik ³ and CAMEL tools were adopted.

To further understand the content and contexts to answer research Q3, topic modeling was performed. All posts were filtered and pre-processed before applying topic modeling algorithms. For this, duplicate posts were removed. Emojis, single letters, character repetitions, stopwords, punctuation, numbers, and special symbols (e.g., #, _, .) were removed as well. For the English posts, the text was converted to lowercase, while for the Arabic posts, the text was filtered to remove elongated words and diacritics, and normalized to unify some letter shapes. The cleaned text was then tokenized to extract its features. For both English and Arabic dataset, we created the LDA model using the Gensim Python library.

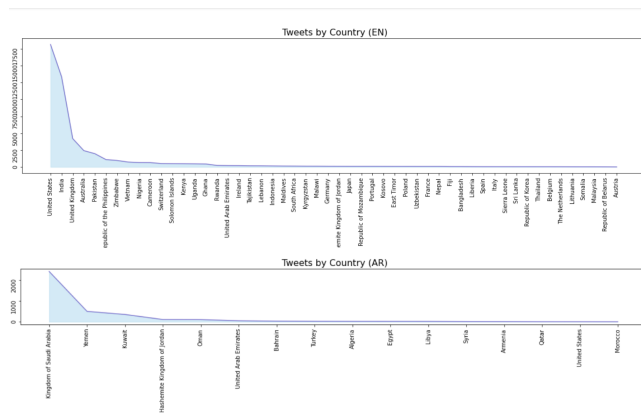


Figure 1: A line chart showing people with disabilities hashtag #PWD #PeopleWithDisabilities tweets number by country and city.

3 Preliminary Results and Discussion

Results show that the majority of English #peoplewithdisabilities posts were posted in the US, Europe, South Africa, South Asia, and Australia. Meanwhile, Arabic posts were mainly from the Middle East and North Africa (MENA). Figure 1 shows the number of tweets based on country and city.

For the English dataset, the largest three posting countries were Canada (27.3%), USA (26.2%), India (19.3%), and United Kingdom (6%) out of a total of 53 countries. For the Arabic dataset, the top posting countries were the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (64.6%), Yemen (13.5%), and Kuwait (9.5%) out of a total of 15 countries. When looking at the Arabic language dialects used, 80% of the posts were in the Arabic - Saudi Arabian dialect, followed by Jordan, Syria, Sudan, and Morocco.

We found that in terms of engagement for Arabic tweets (from a total 10258) 35% were ORG, 0.6% were individuals, 2.2% were miscellaneous and a total of 62% were labeled as Object (ie. not an identifiable entity).⁴ As a verification attempt, the Z.A randomly reviewed 500 account usernames and compared the results and noticed that the automatic classification failed to recognize many individual users as persons. Further manual efforts are needed to enhance the accuracy in future work.

For the English dataset, most engaged tweets were posted by 4 government MP's (3 in Canada 1 in India), 1 NGO in USA, 6 human rights activists in US and Canada. Whilst in Arabic (Table ??) there were 2 Journalists (Saudi Arabia), 1 MP (Saudi Arabia), 8 disability activists/advocates (5 Saudi Arabia/1 Lebanon/1 Kuwait/1 Libya), 3 NGOs (Saudi Arabia), 1 Government authority (Saudi Arabia). The most followed accounts among these tweets were the Government MP's and 1 pwd activist (EN) and 2 activist and 1 journalist from Saudi Arabia (Arabic).

¹<https://perspectiveapi.com/>, <https://aclanthology.org/2020.lrec-1.868/>, <https://www.liwc.app/dictionaries/dict-select>

²<https://textblob.readthedocs.io/en/dev/quickstart.html>

³http://mazajak.inf.ed.ac.uk:8000/api/predict_list

⁴Using CAMEL Named Entity Recognition, Named-entities can either be a LOC (location), ORG (organization), PERS (person), or MISC (miscellaneous)

When analyzing the English dataset sentiment, we found that 50% of the tweets were Positive, 33% Neutral and 17% were Negative. For Arabic 57.3% Neutral, 32.2% Positive and 10.6% Negative.

From top 20 retweeted posts in both languages 35-45% were positive. Only 10% of the highest retweets posts in Arabic were negative but almost 50% were neutral. To understand this more we may likely benefit from more accurate Arabic classification models. From these posts, the positive ones were by governments, MPs and NGOs. The more negative-oriented ones were by activists and advocates.

When investigating tweeting **behaviour**, we found that hashtags associated with the #peoplewithdisabilities hashtag in English were associated with politically oriented campaigns (NDP, ODSP, doubleodspnow, ODSPoverty, onpoll, legislatedpoverty, VoteFord-Out2022, disabilityrights, disabilitybenefits, IDPW/2021, healthcare, oscar). However the Arabic highest retweets included negative language about pwd with terms like autism, charity, holy month, corporate social responsibility (CSR), Apple and bullying a child with a disability.

As for the LDA analysis, both language dataset topic modeling results report some variations among the top keywords within each topic. For the English topic modeling, the topics in order are as follows **disabled health, disabled support, disability life, disabled needs, disabled learning, is disabled inclusion**. Some of the keywords appear in multiple topics; however, their weight varies. For example, pwd, which stands for People With Disability, appears in all topics, but it received the highest weight in disabled inclusion. In comparison, the Arabic data results reports overall lower weights than those reported for the English data. The topic in order as **general disability topic, disabled struggles, disabled needs, disabled organizations, disabled children, disabled support**.

4 Discussion and Recommendations

Our analysis revealed distinct geographic patterns in disability-related discourse across languages. English-language tweets predominantly originated from North America, Europe, South Africa, Canada, and Australia—regions with established advocacy networks and legal frameworks supporting disability rights. In contrast, Arabic-language tweets were concentrated in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA), with Saudi Arabia contributing the largest share, followed by Jordan, Syria, Sudan, and Morocco. This regional distribution reflects both linguistic concentration and varying levels of digital engagement across cultural contexts [25].

Over the three-year period, English-language users were consistently more active with a noticeable upward trend in the use of #peoplewithdisabilities. Arabic users, while significantly less active overall, exhibited sharp spikes in activity around internationally recognized disability-related awareness days—posting rates tripled during those times. Nonetheless, they remained approximately five times less likely to post about disability compared to their English-speaking counterparts.

These findings are consistent with prior research on Arabic-language Twitter engagement surrounding events [5]. This suggests that while Arabic-language disability discourse is more event-driven and less sustained, it may still offer windows of opportunity for impactful, culturally grounded awareness campaigns.

Accordingly, future campaigns and policies should prioritize culturally specific approaches, using latest findings to foster empathy, reduce stigma, and promote inclusivity. Policymakers and advocacy groups must take a more inclusive and supportive approach for diverse audiences. Additionally, for effective social media campaigns, connecting human rights activist, developing awareness, increasing knowledge and driving national adoption of policies and regulation by creating “networks of acknowledgment” [28, 40, 41].

5 Conclusion

The findings underscore the importance of culturally attuned approaches to disability awareness, especially in underrepresented regions of the Global South. While sentiment analysis reveals significant linguistic and emotional differences, it also exposes the limitations of current Arabic NLP tools in capturing nuance and intent. Future work should explore whether these emotional patterns reflect alternative cultural mindsets or underlying models of disability. Expanding this investigation to include emoji usage and developing a tailored emotion classification model specific to disability discourse could further enrich cross-lingual analysis and advance inclusive, context-sensitive research practices.

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